

Building a Bigger Table: Food Research, Methods, Policy, and Action in Library and Information Science

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ABSTRACT

Growing global concerns over food safety, food price inflation, and climate change demand urgent attention in scientific fields. Food information behavior and practice have been a vibrant and growing research area in library and information science, following the user-centered paradigm shift and everyday life information needs, seeking, and use research since the 1970s. Research has shown that people engage with informal and embodied information to guide food practices (e.g., shopping, cooking, eating, and sustainability transitions). Food and health research challenge research methods and approaches in everyday information behavior and inform everyday practices, technological services, policies, and actions. In this panel, following a brief introduction, each panelist will share their research approaches and/or findings about food, health, and information research. We aim to invite and foster an open discussion with audiences to explore research opportunities, challenges, and approaches to studying food in library and information science.

KEYWORDS

Embodiment; everyday information behaviors; information practices; food; serious leisure.

INTRODUCTION

Growing global concerns over food safety, food price inflation, and climate shocks demand urgent attention in scientific fields. Information plays a vital role in guiding consumers and food practitioners (e.g., policy makers, grocers, restaurateurs, and farmers) to make food-related decisions. Various disciplines, including nutrition science, consumer studies, environmental studies, and social sciences, have taken up questions about food and information. In library and information science (LIS), food-related information behaviors and practices have started to draw more attention over the past decade. This area is particularly fruitful for connecting research to practice, policy, and action, as food and eating are a part of everyday life. This panel aims to explore how everyday information behaviors and practices inform food-related research, policy, and action in LIS. The panelists will discuss different methods and approaches to studying food information behavior and explore research opportunities and challenges that inform practices, services, policies, and actions.

BACKGROUND

Everyday life or nonwork-related information needs, seeking, and use research emerged in LIS in the 1970s. The shift from work-oriented to everyday life context builds upon a paradigm shift from a system-centered to a user-centered approach (Dervin & Nilan, 1986). Since then, the interested population and context have kept expanding in LIS, from information seeking of teachers and workers in everyday life (Savolainen, 1995) to information activities of cooking hobbyists in serious leisure (Hartel, 2003). Hartel's works draw upon the theory of serious leisure that was first coined by social scientist Robert Stebbins in 1982 (Stebbins, 2001), which inspired information scholars to study information behaviors in the context of hobbies and everyday mundane life. Hartel's research set the foundations for food-related information behavior and practice research in everyday life. Understanding people's everyday information behaviors and practices is a particularly productive avenue for translational research in LIS. For instance, United Nations' policies indicate that information access, information sharing, database building, and information literacy are important topics to investigate in achieving the UNs' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) (Chowdhury & Koya, 2017). Food labeling, especially ecolabels or green labels (e.g., organic, local), effectively bridges the information gaps between consumers, food providers, and policy makers (Howard & Allen, 2010).

Food information behaviors and practices have been a vibrant and growing research area in LIS over the past decade. Food is not only an essential human need, contributing to health and wellness, but it also helps people form social and cultural identities and bonds; some have argued that food and eating are social acts that make us human (Mol, 2021). Information is often intertwined with individuals' food practices, including acquisition, eating, and cooking. Food-related information also shapes organizational and institutional food practices, such as policies and actions at local and national levels. Food-related research in LIS is mostly focused on everyday life food practices. It reveals not only dynamic food-related practices, such as grocery shopping (Ocepek, 2018), planning and cooking (Hartel, 2006), eating (Polkinghorne, 2021), and ethical consumption behaviors (Polkinghorne, 2021; Du, 2022), but also corresponding sophisticated information practices, including the selection of information sources, information

embodiment, and other information activities. For instance, everyday food consumers encounter and use sensory and embodied information sources to make food choices (Ocepek, 2018), get informed of future cooking and eating practices (Polkinghorne, 2021), or transition to sustainable consumption (Du, 2022). Cooking hobbyists may engage in information activities, such as managing personal collections and creating recipes and action plans at home (Hartel, 2003, 2010). However, how food information behaviors and practices may inform food marketing strategies, formal and informal education, policies, and regulations in everyday life is still implicit. As such, in this panel discussion, we aim to address how research in food information behavior and practices can inform food policies and actions in LIS and invite open discussion on research opportunities, challenges, methods, and approaches to studying food in LIS.

PANEL AGENDA

We will address the following topics in this panel:

- Food information and embodiment
- Methodological considerations for studying food in LIS
- Approaches to US food policy and information practices
- Research partnerships in food and LIS

This 90-minute panel discussion will be organized as follows:

1. The moderator, Xiaotong Du, will introduce the need to explore food information behaviors and practices in library and information science (5 minutes).
2. Each panelist, Sarah Polkinghorne, Melissa Ocepek, Kaitlin Costello, and Xiaotong Du, will present for 10-12 minutes to share their research experience, insights, and how their research, methods, and approaches inform food-related practice, policy, or action (50 minutes).
3. An open discussion, including questions prepared by panelists as a starting point and any questions raised by the audience, for a full discussion with shared audience perspectives (35 minutes).

The prompt questions for open discussion include:

1. How can we address some global food concerns across the entire food system, from production to consumption, through research in library and information science?
2. How can researchers build a bigger table to expand the translational reach of library and information science research, especially to inform policymaking around food?
3. Are there additional approaches to consider when studying food information practices?

PANELISTS AND GOALS

Xiaotong Du, Panelist/Moderator

Xiaotong Du, MA, is a PhD candidate at Rutgers University in the School of Communication & Information. Her research interest lies at the intersection of human information behavior, food, and social and environmental sustainability. Her recent research examines the information behavior and practice of sustainable food consumers in everyday life and food context, including information acquisition to get informed of sustainability-related topics and information practices to guide everyday food acquisition and sustainability transitions. She is a member of the Dining Services and Food Vendors Climate Action Group at Rutgers University. This group aims to reduce indirect carbon emissions from food-related procedures and waste by at least 30% by 2030 at University's food and dining services.

On this panel, Xiaotong will discuss findings from her recent research that may inform food-related practices and actions. She will also discuss her membership in University's climate action group, actions that communities have already taken, and challenges and opportunities to bridge the gap between food-related research findings and actions at the local level.

Sarah Polkinghorne, Panelist

Sarah Polkinghorne, PhD, is a Research Fellow in Social Change at RMIT University in Melbourne, Australia. Her research explores human information practices, with the goal of better understanding how people become informed. In her current work, Dr. Polkinghorne documents people's information practices and technology use as they cope with the rising cost of food. Escalating food costs are central to the global cost-of-living crisis. In its 2022 report on the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), the United Nations reports that the COVID-19 pandemic and concurrent challenges have erased four years of progress toward the eradication of poverty (p. 8). It has become commonplace for media organizations to report on people's coping strategies, including skipping meals ("1 in 4," 2022; Wood, 2022).

People use a range of additional strategies to cope with the cost of food, such as buying cheaper brands and spending less on restaurant meals (Kalaitzondonakes, Coppess, & Ellison, 2022). However, the research evidence on these

strategies is primarily quantitative in nature. Food is intertwined with every aspect of life, including family traditions, geographies and cultures, health needs, sense of self and belonging, and technology use. This means that the information behavior surrounding individual financial and nutritional activities, while important, is not the complete picture. Dr. Polkinghorne uses interpretivist, qualitative approaches in order to generate critical understanding of the lived experiences of the people behind the statistics on skipping meals, foregoing restaurants, and choosing between utilities and groceries.

On this panel, Dr. Polkinghorne will share emerging results from her current phase of research. She will also touch on food's rich potential as a site for exploring current information science concerns such as misinformation, algorithmic bias, and embodiment. Dr. Polkinghorne will raise key initial considerations for information researchers who may be interested in investigating people's food lives.

Melissa Ocepek, Panelist

Melissa Ocepek, PhD, is an Assistant Professor at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign in the School of Information Sciences. Her research draws on ethnographic methods and institutional ethnography to explore how individuals use information throughout their everyday lives. Her research has largely addressed the intersection of food, information and culture including work that examines how shoppers navigate the information environment of the grocery store and why an online grocery shopping platform failed. Dr. Ocepek has published two books related to this work *Food in the Internet Age* and *Formal and Informal Approaches to Food Policy* (both with William Aspray and George Royer). Dr. Ocepek received her Ph.D. at the University of Texas at Austin in the School of Information.

On this panel, Melissa will draw from her many food related projects to share the opportunities for information science through studying food including: tangible material's place in digital culture, studying sensory-based information sources, food's relationship to crisis informatics, and how information can help in feeding the family.

Kaitlin Costello, Panelist

Kaitlin Costello, MSLIS, PhD, is an associate professor at Rutgers University in the School of Communication & Information, where they study health information practices. Their research has included explorations of how people with chronic illnesses find and use online health information in their everyday lives, the use and critique of self-tracking technologies for health, and theory development in library and information science. Dr. Costello's work often questions the assumption that individualized technologies are a net good.

In some contexts, food behaviors, like information behaviors, have been understood through individualized models, and food behavior changes are often framed as individual choices that can be made possible through technology and policy (Schifferstein, 2020). Such models obfuscate that these behaviors are inherently social and collective practices embedded within complex arrangements that are shaped by economic forces like neoliberalism. In this panel, Dr. Costello will discuss the intersections between food, health, and information as commodified devices inscribed in complex assemblages of people, technologies, infrastructures, and geopolitical realities (e.g. Tsing, 2015). They will then suggest considerations for following the "red thread of information" (Bates, 1999) in food information assemblages to an actionable social power analysis that focuses on visible, hidden, and invisible forms of power (Worth, 2022). Understanding the presence, absence, and movement of information and power, as well as the information structures and systems that maintain that power, allows us to strategize for more just futures (Ballester, 2019; Floegel & Costello, 2022). Dr. Costello will draw from their research and the existing literature to explore what an agenda disentangled from neoliberalism could look like for everyday information practices research, and why food is a productive and necessary context in which to situate that work.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

We would like to acknowledge the support and sponsorship of SIG-HLTH.

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